What shapes wellbeing in Somerville

A brief on the Somerville Happiness Survey, 2011 to 2025.

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This is an independent analysis of public City data, not an official City report.

Every two years, Somerville asks residents how happy they are and how they feel about city life. This brief does three things. It checks if the survey hears from everyone fairly. It fixes the gaps it finds. Then it asks what matters most to the residents who are least happy.

Key findings

- The survey hears too little from young adults and renters. In every survey year, adults under 35 and renters answered less often than their real share of the city. The biggest gaps were about 20 points for young adults and 15 points for renters.
- We corrected for this. We gave each answer a weight so the survey matches Census numbers. After this fix, the survey matches the city to within 0.1 point.
- One reported decline was mostly about who answered. Raw numbers showed people liking Somerville less over time. After the fix, the drop is half as big and could be due to chance.
- For the least happy residents, five things matter most: the condition of their housing, worry about being priced out, work opportunities, access to groceries, and relief from summer heat.
- Renters and lower-income residents face these problems most. More than half of renters (56%) are very worried about being priced out of Somerville. Only 19% of owners are.

In 2025, after correcting the survey: 67% of adults said they are happy, 77% said they are satisfied with their life, and 44% said they are very worried about being priced out of Somerville.

Who answers the survey, and why it matters

- A survey only tells the truth about a city if the people who answer look like the city. In Somerville, they don't quite.
- Young adults make up more than half of Somerville's adults. But they send back far fewer surveys. Renters are the same. About two out of three Somerville households rent, but only about half of survey answers come from renters.

How we fixed it

- We used a method called raking. It gives each answer a weight. Answers from groups the survey missed count a little more. Answers from groups it over-counted count a little less. We matched each year's survey to the Census by age and gender, and by renting or owning from 2015 on (the survey did not ask about renting before then).
- The fix worked well. The largest gap left after weighting was 0.1 point. No single answer counts more than about 2.4 times, so no small group of people controls the results.
- Why this matters: Without weighting, the survey mostly reflects older homeowners. Young renters often feel city problems most, so leaving them out can hide those problems.

What the fix changed, and what matters most

- One trend was mostly about who answered
- Ten questions were asked in at least three survey years, so we could track them over time. For eight of them, the trend held up after weighting. Those are real changes.
- One did not. In the raw numbers, satisfaction with Somerville as a place to live fell clearly over time. After weighting, the drop is half as big and is small enough that it could be due to chance. Part of the "decline" happened because the mix of people answering changed from year to year.

What matters most to the least happy residents

- We looked at the residents who rated their happiness 3 or lower out of 5. In 2025, that was about one in three people who answered. For this group, we tested 37 city ratings to see which ones go along with higher life satisfaction. Twenty-four were linked to it. Then we used a method called Shapley analysis to split the credit fairly among the top ten, since many ratings overlap.
- The pattern is clear: for the least happy residents, wellbeing is mostly about housing, money and daily needs. Things like rat control, street repair and arts mattered much less for this group.

Who faces these problems most

- The five drivers do not affect everyone the same way. Renters and lower-income residents report worse experiences on almost all of them.
- Differences by ward
- The problems show up across the whole city, but some wards stand out.

Recommendations

Each recommendation is tied to one of the five drivers and to the groups and wards where the need is greatest.

1. Help renters keep their homes and keep them in good repair

Housing condition and fear of being priced out are the two biggest drivers. Together they make up 41% of the importance. More than half of renters are very worried about being priced out, and renters are much less happy with their housing condition (70% vs. 89% of owners). Focus outreach about tenant rights, repair help and anti-displacement programs on renters, starting in Ward 1, where worry is highest.

2. Connect residents to better work

Work opportunities are the third biggest driver, and the lowest-rated item in this brief. Only about one in three residents is happy with work opportunities, and only 23% of lower-income residents are. Expand job training and job-matching programs for lower-income residents, with extra outreach in Ward 6.

3. Make healthy food easier to get

Grocery access matters for the least happy residents, and it varies a lot by ward: 85% are happy with it in Ward 3, but only 66% in Ward 7. Lower-income residents are also less able to meet basic needs (73% vs. 94%). Look at food pantry hours, mobile markets and transit to grocery stores in Wards 7, 6 and 1.

4. Protect residents from summer heat

Relief from heat is the fifth driver. Renters are less happy with it than owners (64% vs. 75%), likely because many rentals lack good cooling. Expand cooling centers, shade trees and heat alerts, and reach renters directly during heat waves, starting in Ward 1.

A note for the survey team: keep weighting results to Census numbers every year, and try new ways to reach young renters, such as text-message invitations or outreach through landlords and colleges.

How we did this, and what to keep in mind

Data

We used 12,573 adult answers to the Somerville Happiness Survey from eight years: 2011, 2013, 2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023 and 2025. We compared them to the U.S. Census Bureau's American Community Survey 1-year estimates for Somerville. All analysis was done in R, and the code is available on request.

Steps

First, we compared who answered the survey to the Census each year. Second, we used raking to weight each year by age, gender and renting (renting from 2015 on). Third, we tested whether trends over time held up after weighting. Fourth, for 2025, we used weighted ordinal regression to rank 37 city ratings for the least happy residents, adjusting for age, gender and renting. Fifth, we used Shapley analysis on the top ten ratings to split credit fairly among them. Finally, we built 161 weighted tables by ward, age, renting, gender and income.

Limits

The survey years 2013 and 2015 had fewer than 200 answers each, so results from those years are less certain. The 2011 and 2013 surveys did not ask about renting, so those years are weighted by age and gender only. Most city service questions were only asked in 2025, so the drivers analysis covers one year. It shows which things go together with life satisfaction, not what causes it. The model explains a modest share of life satisfaction (pseudo R^2 of 0.10), which is normal for this kind of question. Finally, weighting fixes gaps by age, gender and renting, but other differences between people who answer and people who don't may remain.